

Can "No-Difference" Make a Moral Difference?

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In the actual world, we face the climate change crisis. Some argue that given the current situation, one's Sunday driving does not make any significant changes to GHGs. Therefore, one is permitted to go for a Sunday drive. However, others criticize this by claiming that Sunday driving would bring serious harm, calculating the real harm that emitting GHGs over one's whole life would bring¹. In this paper, I want to consider the case from another aspect. Even if it makes insignificant changes to GHGs, is it permissible for one to go for a Sunday joyride? I think it is still a wrongdoing to choose to go for a Sunday joyride, even if it doesn't cause significant changes to GHGs.

I. Introduction

Global climate change is undeniably one of the most pressing crises of the actual world. Yet, when we attempt to locate individual moral responsibility within this global phenomenon, we encounter a deep philosophical puzzle. If a single agent's daily choices—such as going for a Sunday joyride—do not make a causally significant difference to global greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions, then what really affects GHGs and who is responsible for them?

Many philosophers, most notably Walter Sinnott-Armstrong, argue that because an individual's actions are causally ineffectual in altering the course of global climate change, such actions are morally permissible². However, my central thesis is that moral responsibility in collective harm scenarios is not rooted in causal efficacy, but rather in an agent's contribution to the causal chain. Furthermore, I propose that responsibility is a comparative notion that exists in degrees, determined by how close or far an agent stands from the ultimate consequence.

To establish this claim, the paper will proceed across four sections. In section II, I examine the foundational arguments surrounding individual causal inefficacy within the climate crisis, evaluating the underlying moral intuitions and exploring the theoretical challenges that arise from this framework. Section III, then introduces an alternative conceptual framework for assessing moral responsibility in collective harm contexts, focusing on alternative criteria for evaluating individual actions when direct causal harm is difficult to establish. Furthermore, section IV anticipates and addresses potential objections to the proposed view, exploring how this framework is able to accommodate broader concerns regarding collective action, systemic demandingness, and global distributive justice. In the final section, I conclude that shifting our focus from causal difference-making to individual contribution provides a highly flexible, morally consistent, and realistic path forward for holding individuals responsible in a warming world.

¹ Nolt (2011a;2011b).

² Sinnott-Armstrong (2005).

II. Climate Change and Individual Responsibility³

Imagine that, given the state of the world today—meaning that GHGs have passed the safe threshold and we face a climate change crisis—one wants to go for a Sunday joyride. At first glance, it is not obvious to me whether such an act is permissible or not. Many, like Sinnott-Armstrong, argue that it is permissible because a single Sunday joyride would not make any significant difference with regard to climate change. He appeals to the following principle:

Individual Causal Inefficacy (ICI): Most or all common individual actions, and even full individual lives, are too causally insignificant to make any difference with regard to climate change.

By holding that if an agent's action is too insignificant to make any difference with regard to climate change, then one is permitted to choose that option, and furthermore, since a Sunday joyride is a fitting example of such an option, one's Sunday joyride is permissible.

Hence, there is a real philosophical and ethical question here. Is the difference in harm between performing and not performing an action the correct factor for determining one's responsibility in the context of climate change? First, I do not claim that this harm-difference principle is entirely false. Obviously, it plays a crucial role in our moral lives, but the intuition behind it comes from the opposite side of the ICI. It is the intuition that one should not choose an option with greater harm over an alternative with less harm; however, this says nothing about situations involving a lack of difference between options, such as a Sunday joyride in the context of the current climate change crisis. Therefore, I might accept the ICI and agree that a Sunday joyride is a case where the action is too insignificant to make a difference. Yet, there is a huge gap between accepting this and accepting that this is exactly the reason that makes an action like a Sunday joyride permissible. As I mentioned earlier, I think what is morally relevant is the difference in harm between options, whereas a lack of difference between options is not.

Second, the ICI leads to an odd conclusion. Consider a counterfactual world in which there are no GHGs. In that case, the GHG emissions from one's Sunday joyride would be truly significant, and by the ICI, one would not be permitted to go for a Sunday joyride. Thus, in a better state of the world, one's joyride is not permissible. Conversely, in a worse state of the world, one is permitted to engage in such driving. Therefore, the ICI must be rejected, or at least modified in some way.

Although there are many other critics of Sinnott-Armstrong's view, and some of them focus on the idea that in cases like climate change, there is indeed a difference in harm between a joyride and not riding, I do not intend to focus on that aspect here. Rather, I want to show that even if

³ I borrow this section title from Avram Hiller, "Climate Change and Individual Responsibility," *The Monist* 94, no. 3 (2011): 349–368.

there is no difference in harm, there is still a wrongness in choosing it—and this is what I intend to argue for in the next section.

III. Contribution Matters

Suppose another example, similar to the joyride case, would be helpful here. Suppose I am near a river in which someone is drowning, and the volume of water is so vast that it is certain she will die. In addition, I know that I cannot save her since I do not know how to swim, and I have a bottle of water in my hands. In this situation, it is obvious that it is at least *prima facie* wrong for me to pour the water from my bottle into the river. Thus, if we accept that there are no morally relevant differences between the Sunday joyride case and the drowning case, then, just as in the river case, one's Sunday joyride would be *prima facie* wrong.

So, what is really determinative in the drowning example? I think what matters in these kinds of cases is an agent's contribution. It is true that the contribution is too insignificant to be considered a cause of the harm, but in my view, what determines one's responsibility is not one's causal role in the chain of harm, but rather one's contribution to that causal chain. Once one adds water to the river, one has contributed to the harm occurring to the drowning person.

It is worth noting that I understand the notion of responsibility as a comparative notion. In other words, in my view, responsibility is a matter of degree. One can be more responsible for an action than another. Correspondingly, this holds true for compensation, which means that one who is more responsible must compensate more. Therefore, what is important here is that I do not grant the same weight of responsibility to each causal element in the causal chain. Rather, one's causal role is important for determining their degree of responsibility, and by "causal role," I mean one's closeness to the consequence of the causal chain, which is the harm here. Thus, I attribute responsibility to the person near the river because of her contribution, but her insignificant causal role or her distance from the consequence of the causal chain leads me to grant her a lesser compensatory obligation.

IV. Possible Objections

First, one may claim that it is not obvious that pouring a bottle of water into the river is wrong. Hence, I want to present that argument in another way. Suppose one has an empty bottle, and thus has the alternative option of filling the bottle with water from the river. If one chooses to fill the bottle, thereby decreasing the volume of water in the river, then this action has an inherent goodness, at least in a weak sense. This goodness might stem from the sense of care demonstrated by attempting to decrease the water volume of the river. Although it is too insignificant to be effective, the action still possesses some notion of goodness in itself. If one accepts this line of thought, then what accounts for the difference between this action and adding a bottle of water to the river? There is a symmetry between these two cases. Whatever credit one grants to an agent for reducing the water volume must be granted, correspondingly, as blame to an agent who adds water to the river. If the former is praiseworthy, then the latter must be blameworthy. I do not see any evidence that can break this symmetry.

Second, one might object that by widening the scope of responsibility to the furthest agents in a causal chain, as I have suggested, too many people would be held responsible for climate change, making the theory overly demanding. However, this is exactly what I intend to do here. If this is the case, it allows us to conceptualize the collective nature of the problem; furthermore, there is no purely individualistic approach available to solve climate change. Yet, this is a highly complicated issue that I do not wish to focus on here. It is simply a view that opens a path toward investigating collective or group responsibility.

Another interesting objection can be raised: in the actual world, a significant portion of GHG emissions comes from developing countries, and it seems unfair to attribute the same level of responsibility to their citizens as to those living in developed countries. Here, two approaches can be taken. The first suggests that a person living in a developed country should be regarded as less responsible if their immediate group produces a smaller volume of GHGs overall. The second suggests that because developed countries achieved their status by exploiting developing nations and outsourcing their manufacturing to those regions, the burden of responsibility should not fall on developing countries. Instead, precisely because they are developed nations with greater resources and opportunities, they bear a higher responsibility for climate change. My theory remains neutral here and is compatible with both views. All I have suggested is that the determinative element for responsibility is an agent's contribution, but as I mentioned above, the notion of responsibility is a matter of degree. Thus, while there may be many considerations that affect this degree, my theory remarkably considers everyone who emits GHGs to be responsible, regardless of whether they live in a developing or a developed country.

V. Conclusion

In this paper, I have investigated the persistent ethical puzzle of individual moral responsibility in the context of global climate change. By examining Walter Sinnott-Armstrong's defense of the Sunday joyride, I have shown that relying strictly on the Principle of Individual Causal Inefficacy (ICI) leads to highly counterintuitive and logically problematic conclusions when applied to counterfactual scenarios. Instead of accepting that having no causal impact makes an action permissible, I have argued for a change in how we think about morality. By separating causal efficacy from contribution, we can locate the source of an agent's responsibility in their contribution to a causal chain of harm.

Furthermore, framing responsibility as a comparative notion—one that is fundamentally a matter of degree based on an agent's closeness to the consequence—allows this account to remain highly flexible. As explored in the analysis of potential objections, this model successfully preserves the moral symmetry between harmful additions and beneficial reductions, while remaining neutral and adaptable to the complex realities of global distributive justice. Ultimately, recognizing that contribution matters ensures that we do not dismiss individual actions as morally negligible, but instead open a conceptually rigorous path toward addressing both individual and collective responsibility in our warming world.

References

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